our professors, began to march across the campus toward the chapel, and soon it was filled to overflowing.

Because I was a freshman and didn't have the same vested interests in avoiding the faculty cutbacks that upperclassmen did, I was chosen to present our committee's proposal for a strike.

I reviewed how the cutbacks threatened not only the diplomas of upperclassmen but the academic reputation of Eureka; I described how the administration had ignored us when we tried to present alternate ideas for saving money and then planned to pull off the coup in secrecy while we were gone from the college.

Giving that speech—my first—was as exciting as any I ever gave. For the first time in my life, I felt my words reach out and grab an audience, and it was exhilarating. When I'd say something, they'd roar after every sentence, sometimes every word, and after a while, it was as if the audience and I were one. When I called for a vote on the strike, everybody rose to their feet with a thunderous clapping of hands and approved the proposal for a strike by acclamation.

The strike began when we returned after Thanksgiving. Most students refused to go to class, while studying privately in their rooms; most of our professors went to class, marked the missing students present, and then went home.

A week after the strike began, the president resigned, the strike ended, and things returned to normal at Eureka College.

The following summer, I resumed my old lifeguarding job at Lowell Park and at summer's end decided that I'd tolerated Mac McKinzie's lack of appreciation for my gridiron skills long enough.

Most of my savings were gone and I didn't have enough left for another year at Eureka, and I wasn't sure I wanted to go back there.